how survey engineers on Kawasaki bikes decided on the rail alignment to kick off work. [142]

Office within a Week

Within days of the corporation being set up, the team already felt like a well-knit family that had a job to do, quickly. There was no time to waste and the managing director of Konkan Railways, Mr E. Sreedharan, brought home the message forcefully. Three days after B. Rajaram arrived in the city he received a call from Mr Sreedharan. ‘I’m coming in two days,’ Mr Sreedharan told him. ‘I want to see the alignments.’ Mr Rajaram at that point had nothing more than ₹5 lakh and a briefcase. He knew few people in Panaji and had no fixed address. Yet, these factors were by no means going to be allowed to hinder progress. ‘It was the finest example of how Mr Sreedharan worked.’

Meeting the challenge head-on, Mr Rajaram went to Vasco, hired khalasis, [143] tore up a piece of red cloth to make ‘flags’, found some stones and set to work, charting out the alignment. By the time Mr Sreedharan arrived, Mr Rajaram had decided on eight locations and three river crossings.

By this time, Mr Rajaram also succeeded in setting up an office—a flat provided to him by Carmo Gracias, an acquaintance he had met a couple of days earlier for the first time at a party—and furnished it by purchasing furniture from Godrej.

It just happened that the furniture was readily available at that point because the Goa government had ordered it. But when Mr Rajaram produced his cheque book and said he would pay at once, Godrej had no choice but to give it to him instead. This was a most unusual way indeed for the railways to work!

‘Godrej could not believe that someone from the railways was functioning in this manner,’ smiles Mr Rajaram.

‘Then they got excited.’ Mr Rajaram’s behaviour was all the more astonishing because he then said, pointing to a typist in the office, ‘I want that typewriter. And—what’s that girl’s name? I want the girl too!’

By 10.30 a.m. the next day, minutes before Mr Sreedharan arrived, there was a fully functional office, and the beginnings of the alignment in Goa. The typewriter was there too, and so was the typist. Little details, like